REP-087 · Kickstarter art direction: audit, recommendation and pilot plan

Game	Fruit Market 1.7.0 (rules version 9). No game, app or print-kit change.
Report date	2026-11-07 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur). Corrected the same morning after an internal review, before delivery.
Type	Audit and recommendation. No images were generated and no assets were built.
Request	"Audit the existing Fruit Market art direction and character requirements. Recommend the strongest visual identity for a Kickstarter-first tabletop release with a subsequent mobile adaptation. Propose the first two characters to develop … and present a concrete production plan. Do not generate or implement assets yet."
Status	Awaiting the owner's approval: DEC-063 (art direction) and PLAN-048 (first, unpaid part of the pilot). The proposed direction is in `docs/art/ART_DIRECTION.md` (v0.2).

1. The short version

1. **Recommendation: a controlled hybrid, "Look E".** The world, frames and graphics take the crate-label style of "The Great Fruit Exchange". The people take the personality of "Orchard & Oddballs", but stay ordinary townsfolk. Everything is drawn in one flat screen-print style in today's palette, plus a few additions for your approval.
2. **Three AI review passes agreed.** Each was written from one viewpoint (tabletop publisher, art-production lead, game identity) and scored the options out of 45: hybrid 35 to 36, Oddballs alone 25 to 27, Exchange alone 22 to 25. They are not outside experts. Treat them as a structured opinion. The scores per criterion are in appendix A.
3. **The pixel look you like stays on the phone's board.** In the rule "the board shows tokens; cards show portraits", illustrated portraits go on printed cards, the box, the store and a few card views in the app. **The trade-off:** during play the phone shows the same people as pixel tokens, not as the new pictures (question 2).
4. **Pilot characters: Benny (shopkeeper) and Sailor Jia Wen (customer).** They are the most different pair that is safe for hidden information.
5. **Biggest commercial risk: AI art on Kickstarter.** From search summaries, not yet checked on the source pages: Kickstarter allows AI art but requires a public disclosure section, and board-game backers react strongly. UK Games Expo bars products made "completely or in significant part" with AI and does not define "significant". AI drafts finished by a person may still be refused there.
6. **Biggest game risk: art giving away secrets.** A customer's freshness type, amounts and prices are fixed by who they are. A face, a back or an edge colour that varies by card would reveal them. ART_DIRECTION.md §9 sets nine hard rules, including a fixed fruit order on customer backs (today's backs already make 9 of 36 customers unique).
7. **Fix before anything is printed:** the Drive print kit is still rules version 8, and RULES.md disagrees with the game on the generous customers and the guest orders.
8. **Cost:** nothing is spent without a quote and your approval. Estimates: 45 card portraits by a human illustrator about USD 4,500 to 36,000, plus USD 1,000 to 6,000 for a box cover. The

recommended route (AI drafts plus a person's finishing) is about USD 2,250 to 6,750 for 45 portraits, plus the tool and the box. All of this is far above the RM500-a-month ceiling.

2. What was audited

- **Repo:** art code (`src/ui/pixel.tsx`, `propsArt.tsx`, `art.tsx`, `wearArt.ts`, `looks.ts`, `palette.ts`), the style guide, the creative bible, RULES.md, `src/engine/data.ts`, the online server's hidden-information code, tests and the print script.
- **Records:** every art, cast, look and print decision (DEC-014 to DEC-062) and reports REP-010 to REP-086.
- **Google Drive (read only):** the Print_Kit folder (51-page home-print PDF), Look_Comparison, Board_Look_Options, Cast_Coherence_Audit, and the Concept and Studio Lifecycle Companions.
- **Outside research:** Kickstarter's AI policy, backer and convention reactions, copyright of AI images (US, UK, EU, Malaysia), image-tool terms, factory print specifications, tool features and illustrator prices.
- **Method:** six parallel AI audits, then three AI review passes from different viewpoints, then a second set of three AI reviewers who tried to prove the drafts wrong. Their corrections are in this version. I re-checked the key repo claims against the code by hand.

3. What exists today

- **All art is drawn in code.** Fruit, icons, props and 50 people are text grids turned into small pictures. Portraits are 16 × 16 pixels from one shared face, told apart by hair, accessory, skin and shirt (DEC-041). There are no image files to replace.
- **Swapping art is clean.** Every screen asks for a portrait through one function (`Face` in `src/ui/art.tsx`), and names, quirks, perks and freshness types live separately in `data.ts`. A new portrait source would need no change to rules, saves or online play.
- **The 25 collectible looks** are 11 wearables drawn as pixel rows on the 16 × 16 face, plus 14 stall pieces. Wearables only work on the pixel face, which is why Look E keeps them there.
- **Print is thin and partly outside the repo.** Only the card-back script is in the repo (63 × 88 mm, no bleed, no crop marks, RGB). Customer, shopkeeper, mat and token pages were generated elsewhere. They are rules version 8 and lack the freshness type.
- **Printed portraits are small:** about 21 mm (customers) and 26 mm (shopkeepers), drawn from 16 × 16 pixels. They are the weakest asset for a polished Kickstarter box.
- **Your recorded taste:** you chose a smooth toy-box look (DEC-021, "go with plan b"), then moved back to pixel art twice (DEC-023, DEC-033 "Look C"), and praised the current look ("artstyle is awesome i love it", DEC-057). That is why Look E keeps pixel art on the board and shows every new design beside today's look before anything is built (DEC-042).
- **Precedent for AI art:** the lorry picture was made with Gemini, and you accepted that AI-made art may not be protected by copyright (history, PLAN-011). It was later replaced by pixel art for consistency (DEC-052).

4. The two directions, scored

- **The Great Fruit Exchange alone:** strong shelf appeal and a perfect match for lorries, events and the box. But many historic crate labels and fruit ads drew people as racist or "exotic"

caricatures. Copying real labels risks copyright and trademark claims: brands such as Sunkist and Chiquita appear to still use their marks, though no trademark search has been run. Detailed litho texture also blurs at phone sizes.
- **Orchard & Oddballs alone:** good personality and social energy. But "charming imperfection" is what AI tools keep least consistent. It slides toward exaggerated faces (against DEC-018 and DEC-041), and without a strong graphic frame it looks like generic mobile-game art.
- **Hybrid:** the Exchange supplies the graphics as code templates (no image generator), so every frame and edge is identical. Oddballs supplies the attitude, expressed only through pose, prop and expression. One flat style ties them together. Its one weakness is that each person has two renderings, and a shared character spec keeps them in step.

Totals out of 45 (the scores per criterion are in appendix A):

	Exchange alone	Oddballs alone	Hybrid
Publisher view	23	27	36
Production view	25	25	36
Identity view	22	27	35

5. The recommendation

Look E, as written in `docs/art/ART_DIRECTION.md`: principles, colour, type, proportions, line and texture, card layouts, print sizes, hidden-information rules, AI consistency rules and a banned list. It keeps the harbour world (DEC-017) and the townsfolk cast rules (DEC-039, DEC-040). Three changes need your approval:

- DEC-041's portrait rule becomes "one character spec, two renderings".
- Up to three skin tones and a few accent colours join the palette.
- One bold display face is added for printed titles.

ART_DIRECTION §12 lists every approved record it touches.

6. Pilot characters

Recommended: Benny (shopkeeper, Big Basket) + Sailor Jia Wen (customer, card 25).

	Benny	Sailor Jia Wen
Role	Shopkeeper; public perk; computer rival in the daily market	Everyday customer; wants 2 apples (top $6) and 2 mangoes (top $10)
Shape	Broad, round, bearded, steady	Slim, upright, quick
Colour	Warm brown shirt, skin tone c	Harbour navy, skin tone a
Head	Short dark hair and beard (a clean base for hats later)	Long black hair; the bible will propose a sailor's cap as her one accessory
Prop	The big basket (his perk is public, so showing it is fine)	A rolled "mango map" (her quirk), not coins, so no money cue

- **Why Benny:** a shopkeeper appears on the player card, box, Kickstarter page, app avatar and character pick. His broad build tests the bust template. His perk gives a natural prop, and his simple head makes the cleanest anchor for wearable looks later.
- **Why Jia Wen:** she carries the identity of "a harbour where the whole world comes to shop". Her back never singles her out. On today's backs (fruits in card order) it matches one Premium and one Bargain card. With the fixed order it would match two Premium, one Bargain and one other Everyday card. Her portrait tests the process: a prop chosen with no money cue, and the cue-balance check. She is Everyday and not generous in either list.
- **Contrast:** man and woman, broad and slim, warm and cool colours, bare head and cap, a shopkeeper's hero card and a small customer window.
- **What the pair does not cover:** guest cards, event-card people and the face-down walk-in figure. The walk-in figure is specified in the Character Bible.
- **Runners-up:** Rosa + Grandpa Tan (Rosa's bun and glasses are the hardest test for hats and the monocle). Raj + Grandpa Tan (the deepest skin tone tests printing and small sizes). Note: Tan's thrift quirk cannot be drawn literally until you decide its text, and his token has two accessories, so choosing him means settling both first.
- **Not a pilot yet:** Rara Jenab. She is your own approved design and a strong campaign face, but as a Premium card her back is unique today (section 11, item 4).

7. Production plan

Each stage ends with a stop for your approval. Nothing visual is built before you approve its design (DEC-042). PLAN-048 covers stages 1 to 3, which need no spending. Stages 4 and 5 become a second plan once dated quotes exist.

Stage	Your brief	What happens	Output	Gate
0 (now)	Phase 1	Audit and direction	This report, ART_DIRECTION.md v0.2	You approve Look E and PLAN-048, and answer three questions
1	Phase 2, in two steps	Character Bible: one line each for all 45 characters plus the walk-in figure (build, shape, hair, prop, colours, type-cue check, fixes needed); full entries and master prompts for the two pilots; style-lock sheet layout. The other full entries follow in waves (your rule: never the whole roster at once).	CHARACTER_BIBLE.md v0.1	You approve
2	Phase 5 (templates)	Card template design: a mock-up of one customer (densest card), one guest and one shopkeeper front, plus the customer back, beside today's card. Built only after you approve. Then rules-9 templates filled from `data.ts`, with bleed, crop marks and an empty portrait window, as home-print sheets and one-card-per-page PDFs.	Mock-up, then templates and print script	You approve the mock-up

Stage	Your brief	What happens	Output	Gate
3	Phase 3, steps 1 to 4	Pilot concepts: three directions per pilot with full prompts, scored on silhouette, personality, appeal and card readability, with a recommendation. The tool is chosen after a dated check of its terms.	Prompts, specs, scored concepts	You pick one per pilot
4	Phase 3, steps 5 to 8	Pilot masters: master reference, front, three-quarter and side views, six expression sheets (as drawing references), a person's finishing of the shipped pictures, script checks, manifest entries, and a mock-up of the matching pixel token	Masters on Drive, manifest	Quote approved first; you approve the masters
5	Phase 4	QA and style lock: eight scores per character, each at least 4/5; printed at 100% on the template; phone mock-up next to today's look	Style-lock sheet	You approve the style lock
6	Phases 2 to 4, repeated	Waves: five more shopkeepers (Rosa first), then customers in waves of 6 to 8, guests, the Health Inspector and the walk-in figure	Each wave	Each wave approved
7	Phase 6	Commercial readiness: box key art, factory quote and spec, printed proof, provenance and licence review, Kickstarter "Use of AI" section, font credits, name and logo trademark check	Launch pack	Separate approvals; spending needs a quote
8	Phase 5 (phone assets)	Phone adoption: card views show portraits; pixel tokens may be redrawn to match; tests; performance budget; old saves keep loading	App release	A separate plan

Images in this session: no image-generation tool is available here. For stage 3 I will prepare complete prompts and specifications for an outside tool. You (or I, in a session with a tool) make the images. I will not describe images I have not received.

QA scores (stage 5): identity consistency, distinctiveness, visual appeal, personality, tabletop readability, phone readability, style consistency and production readiness, each 1 to 5, all at least 4, scored by the reviewer and confirmed by you. Automatic flags: anatomy errors, clothing or face changes between views, an unclear silhouette at 44 px, details that only read when zoomed, and any text, symbol or type cue.

8. Asset structure (proposal; created at stage 4)

Where	What
`docs/art/`	ART_DIRECTION.md, CHARACTER_BIBLE.md, STYLE_LOCK.md
`art/index.json`	One short row per asset version: ID (the existing character key, never renamed), version, use, status, approval
`art/templates/`	Card frames and backs (SVG or HTML)
`scripts/print-cards.cjs`	Builds RGB print PDFs from templates, game data and portraits (the existing browser route). CMYK at factory hand-off, either by the factory

Where	What
	or with one added tool after a dependency decision.
Drive `Fruit Market/Art_Masters/<id>/v001/`	Accepted raw images, layered source, finished transparent master (2048 px or larger), turnarounds, expression sheet, and the full manifest row (tool, model version, prompt, references, terms checked, human changes). Never overwritten: a change makes v002.
Generated, never hand-made	Print PDFs (with bleed), phone images (WebP at 1x, 2x and 3x), Kickstarter images

Large masters and the full manifest live on Drive, so the repo, the Android build and the one-file web build stay small, and model names stay out of the repo. Game data, words, prices, symbols and frames stay separate from the pictures, so a rule change never means redrawing art.

9. AI, copyright and Kickstarter

All outside facts here come from web search summaries. Fetching the primary pages was blocked in this session, so each must be re-checked on its source page, with a date, before a decision depends on it.

- **Kickstarter** allows AI content but requires a public "Use of AI" section: which tools, which parts are AI, which are original, and whether the owners of the source works gave consent. Hiding AI use can get a project suspended.
- **Backers:** board-game buyers are among the most hostile audiences. Reported examples: review-bombing of an AI cover on BoardGameGeek (March 2026), UK Games Expo barring products made "completely or in significant part" with AI (from September 2026; "significant" undefined), BackerKit barring content made only by AI, and award and publisher bans. Observational studies of Kickstarter campaigns (all categories, 2022 to 2024) link AI disclosure to clearly lower funding. Reported effects range from about 40% less money to about half the odds of reaching the goal.
- **Copyright:** the US Copyright Office (January 2025) says prompts alone do not make you the author; human changes, and the selection and arrangement of material, can be protected. Separately, the courts confirmed that an AI cannot be an author (Thaler; the Supreme Court declined to hear it in March 2026). The UK may remove its computer-generated-works rule. Malaysia's Copyright Act 1987 has no AI provision and no court cases yet, and a consultation ran in 2026. Raw AI images may give no exclusive rights, so copycats could reuse them.
- **Tool terms:** most tools give you whatever rights exist in the output. Protection against infringement claims is offered mainly on business or API plans (for example Adobe Firefly for enterprise, OpenAI's business and API plans, Google Vertex), with conditions to check. Consumer plans (about USD 10 to 50 a month) do not include it. Midjourney offers none found, is being sued by major studios, and shows lower-tier images in a public gallery, so it is not recommended for shipped art.
- **Recommended policy:**
  - AI for ideas and drafts.
  - A person finishes every shipped character picture.
  - The box and key art come from a named, credited artist with no AI drafts. Without budget, use a type-and-frame box instead of an AI picture.
  - Frames and graphics are made as code templates.

- A manifest for every asset.
- A full, honest "Use of AI" section, which also mentions that an AI coding assistant wrote the template code and the existing pixel art.
- If showing at conventions such as UK Games Expo matters, the final character art needs to be made by a human artist, not only finished by one.

10. Costs (estimates only; no quotes yet)

Item	Estimate	Source
Image tool	about USD 10 to 50 a month (consumer plans), or about USD 0.03 to 0.24 per image through an API	Vendor pages, via search summaries
A person's finishing	about USD 50 to 150 per finished picture	An AI reviewer's estimate, not a quote
Recommended route, 45 card portraits	about USD 2,250 to 6,750, plus the tool and the box	45 × the row above
Full illustration per card	about USD 100 to 800	LaunchBoom, Stonemaier, Pine Island guides
45 card portraits by a human illustrator	about USD 4,500 to 36,000	45 × the row above; head-and-shoulders work usually sits in the lower half
Box cover	about USD 1,000 to 6,000	Same guides
Pilot (two shipped pictures)	about USD 110 to 350 (one month of a tool plus two finished pictures)	Arithmetic from the rows above; reference sheets are not repainted

The RM500-a-month ceiling (DEC-005) covers all games, so the pilot alone may use most or all of one month, depending on the exchange rate. A Kickstarter art budget would be a separate, one-off decision. The Studio Lifecycle Companion on Drive also recommends a separate launch budget. Nothing is spent until you approve a dated quote.

11. Problems found on the way (not art; for later)

1. **Generous customers disagree:** RULES.md lists 12 (including John, Grace and Lakshmi). The game computes 13 (including Daniel, Siti, Anna and Marcus). Checked by recomputing from `data.ts`.
2. **Guest orders disagree, and RULES.md disagrees with itself.** Its event table matches the game (Influencer 2 mangoes at $12, Gym Club 3 blueberries at $8, Hotel Chef 2/1/1, all at fixed prices). Its guest-card table says 3 at $11, 4 blueberries and 3/2/2. Its next line says the event's price change still applies, but the game treats guest prices as fixed.
3. **The Drive print kit is rules version 8:** no freshness type, the old "Not so" wording, old prices.
4. **Card backs list fruits in each card's own order,** in the printed kit, the app and the online server. That makes 9 cards unique from the back, including Premium Rara Jenab. A fixed fruit order would leave 4. (Separately, the fruit set alone already settles the type for 19 of 36 cards. That is how the rules work and is not changed here.)
5. **The online leak check** tests only the amounts and prices on face-down walk-ins. It does not test that the name, freshness type or generous flag are hidden. Only the server's allow-list protects them today, and Look E's app rule depends on the name staying hidden.

6. **The face-down "shopper" face** looks like Benny (same short hair and brown shirt).
7. **Likely bug (read in code, not reproduced):** online, any favour card a rival plays is announced as "Priority!" (`src/ui/game/animator.tsx` with the server's hidden-favour placeholder).
8. **Cast leftovers:** a fox sprite, 13 unused creature and costume parts, "animal traders" comments in `data.ts`, the creative bible's identity line still listing vampires and mermaids (DEC-039 removed creatures), and 11 sprites with two accessories against the one-accessory rule.
9. **Misleading quirks:** Bargain Wei Jie inspects fruit with a magnifier, Bargain Mei Ling splashes sellers of soggy fruit, Everyday Zul "wants fresh fruit".
10. **Store, launcher and splash art** use an older, off-palette style. No font licence or credit file exists.
11. **STATE.md was out of date** (it said 1.2.0 was live; the release records say 1.7.0 was published on 2026-11-07). Its top section is updated.

Items 1, 2, 4 and 5 need small plans of their own. Each changes text, app or test code, so none is inside PLAN-048.

12. Evidence quality and limits

- **Repo claims** were checked against the code. The generous list, guest orders, back uniqueness, walk-in redaction and the leak check were re-run or re-read by hand.
- **Outside figures** come from web search summaries (section 9). Prices and terms change often.
- **Records check:** `npm run records:check` PASS on 2026-11-07.
- **NOT RUN:** a physical print test; any image generation; a factory quote; a legal opinion on Malaysian copyright; a trademark search.
- **Not applicable:** lint, types, unit tests and build. No game code changed.

13. Questions for you

Approval asked: DEC-063 (Look E) and PLAN-048 (Character Bible, card-template design, pilot prompts: no spending).

1. **Final character art:** (A, recommended) AI drafts, with every shipped picture finished by a paid, credited artist; or (B) AI drafts finished only by you, with no artist. Both must be disclosed on Kickstarter. Answering A lets me collect dated quotes for a one-off art budget outside RM500 a month. Nothing is spent until you approve one.
2. **Phone game:** keep the pixel people on the board, home screen and wardrobe, with illustrated portraits only on cards, box, store and the character pick (recommended)? Or replace the pixel people everywhere? That means redrawing the 11 wearable looks for every shopkeeper and making each portrait readable at 18 to 34 px. The 14 stall looks are not affected.
3. **Pilots:** Benny + Sailor Jia Wen (recommended), Rosa + Grandpa Tan, or Raj + Grandpa Tan?

Assumptions unless you say otherwise:

- Kickstarter means a factory-made box (open since REP-038).
- The product name stays *Fruit Market*.

- The text mismatches in section 11 are fixed by a small separate plan. Until then, PLAN-048's test print is a marked draft using the game's data.
- Jia Wen is drawn as a young woman (her sprite has long hair).
- The six expressions in your brief are drawing references and marketing art, not app frames (DEC-042).

Appendix A · Scores per criterion

Each cell shows publisher / production / identity view, from 1 (poor) to 5 (strong).

Criterion	Exchange alone	Oddballs alone	Hybrid
Kickstarter appeal	4 / 4 / 4	3 / 3 / 4	5 / 5 / 5
Originality and IP safety	2 / 2 / 2	3 / 3 / 3	4 / 4 / 3
Fit with the world	3 / 3 / 3	3 / 3 / 3	4 / 4 / 4
Distinct across 45 characters	2 / 2 / 2	5 / 5 / 4	4 / 4 / 4
AI consistency	3 / 4 / 3	2 / 2 / 2	4 / 4 / 4
Print readability	4 / 4 / 3	3 / 3 / 3	4 / 4 / 4
Phone readability	2 / 2 / 2	3 / 3 / 3	4 / 4 / 4
Cost for a solo developer	2 / 3 / 2	2 / 1 / 2	3 / 3 / 3
Stereotype safety (5 = safest)	1 / 1 / 1	3 / 2 / 3	4 / 4 / 4
Total (of 45)	**23 / 25 / 22**	**27 / 25 / 27**	**36 / 36 / 35**